



the populist gaze

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Let's start with a little exercise. Close your eyes. And think about the political information that you consumed this week, when you were chilling in your accommodation, having a super instagrammable coffee, or when your mind got distracted your thumb mobility was non-existent. Hold on to the article, post, or instance that comes to mind. Now I ask you to stand still with the modality of this memory - is it visual? Is it moving? Is there a textual or verbal connotation to it, or is it just that?

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You can open your eyes now. Today I am very excited to tell you about the third project of my PhD in political communication which is called the Populist Gaze. Why?

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Well, populism... although it has never really left us, it is arguably stronger than it has ever been to date.

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And there are plentiful shades of populism: Mudde's thin ideology, Laclau's obscure discourse, Moffit's populist style (which genZ would rather translate to "vibe"), and De Vreese's "content": a little bit of everything.

And since science is always late to the party - it was only until shit hit the fan in 2016 when we picked up populism as study subject. And with result, because we do know A LOT about it. So what brings me to the party?

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What fascinates me is the gaze in political communication, and populism in particular.

the populist gaze

the power of



looking

6

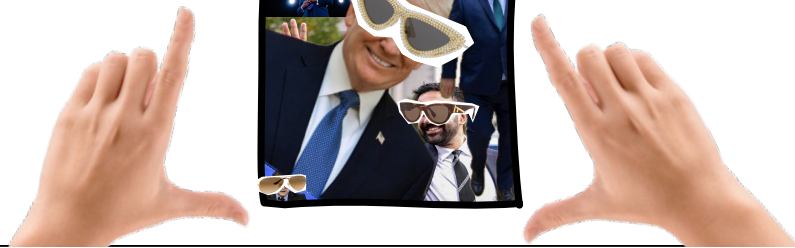
I see it as the interplay between the power of looking,

the populist gaze

the power of



showing

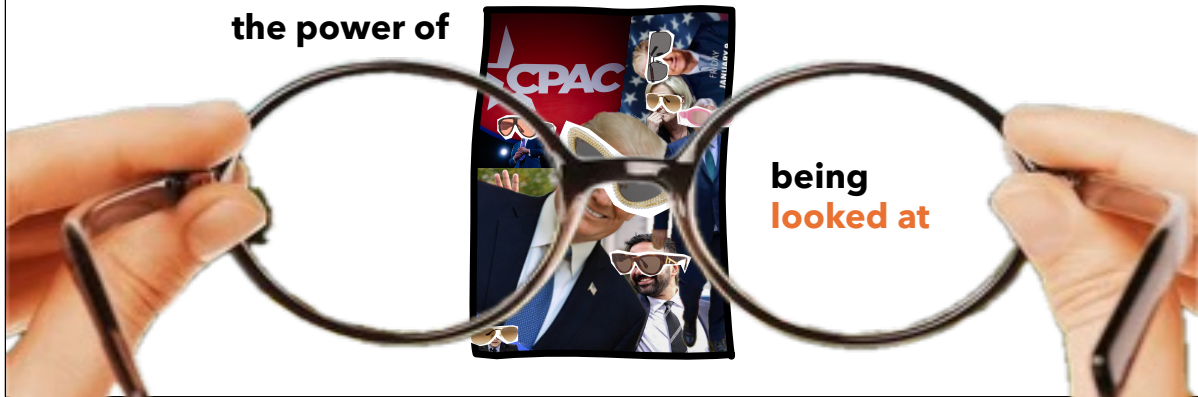


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the power of showing

the populist gaze

the power of



being
looked at

, and the power of being looked at (which we extensively spoke about yesterday).

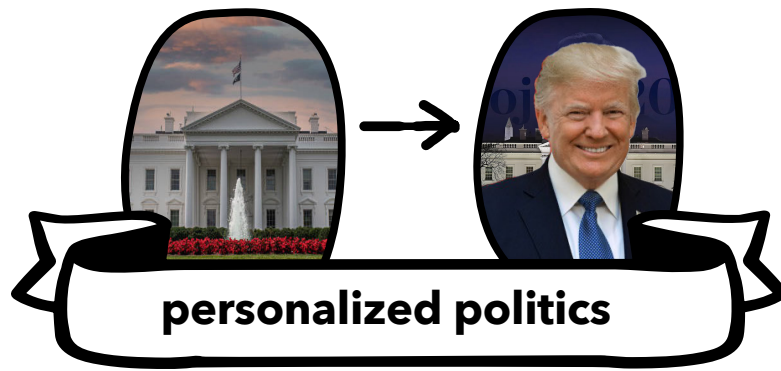
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And this has a lot to do with the relationship between media and politics, which is increasingly shaped by...

the populist gaze



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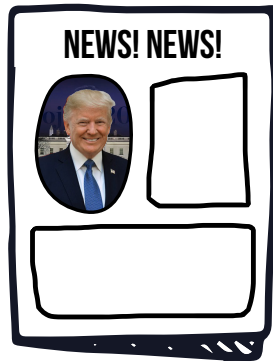
...politicians and our obsession with them.

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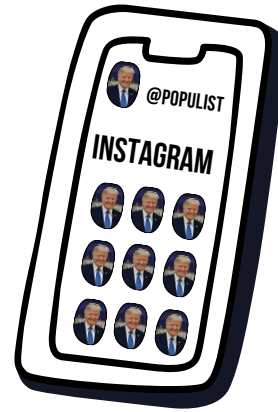


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We perceive political communication as more personalised than before. And populism, with a remarkably noble role for the strong and charismatic leader of the harmless pure racist xenophobic far right people, lends itself very well for personalised politics.



**media/mediated
populism**

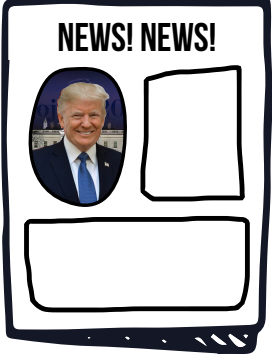


**strategic
populism**

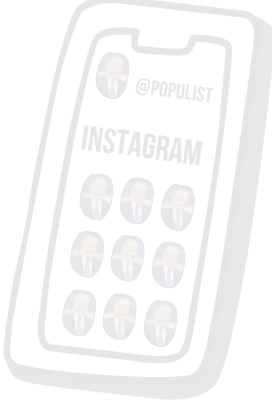
Literature defines two ways of populism in online media.

the populist gaze

Krämer, B. (2014). Media Populism: A Conceptual Clarification and Some Theses on its Effects: Media Populism. *Communication Theory*, 24(1), 42–60.
<https://doi.org/10.1111/commt.12029>



**media/mediated
populism**

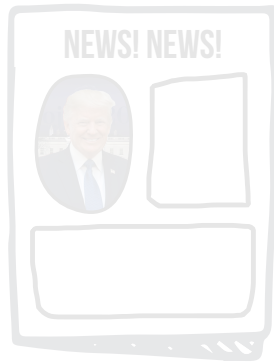


**strategic
populism**

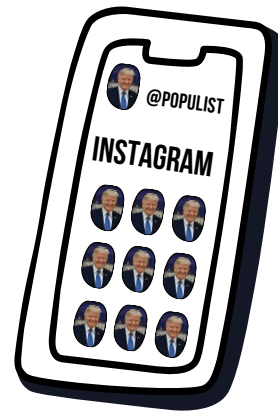
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On the one hand we have media and mediated populism. Media populism, or populism BY the media, concerns a way of reporting, a worldview imposed by journalists, editors, outlets, that mirrors the contrast between the people and the elite. The media is active by framing something something in a populist way.

But there's also mediated populism, with which the echoing of populists' statement is meant. Think of a headline where Wilders or Le Pen are quoted with a populist statement. This is populism THROUGH the media - think of it as slipping through the gate.

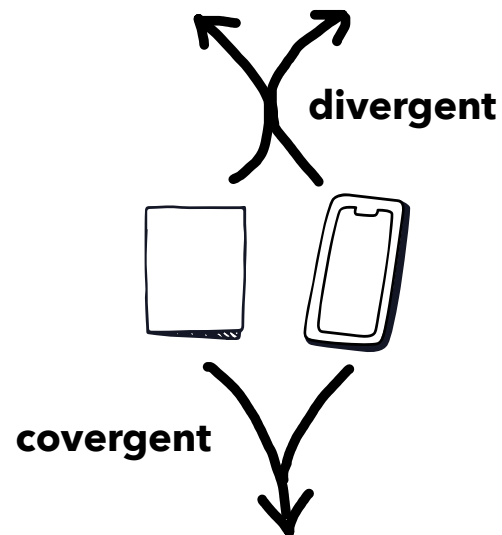


media/mediated
populism



strategic
populism

And then... Strategic populism, namely by politicians on their social media channels, in talkshows, through influencers...



My question is: do these two types converge or diverge?

If so, on which dimensions of populism? Around which topics, and regarding which actors?

To what extent is **populist** communication used in

visual and textual messages within strategic

communication (i.e., political elites' social media

content) and mediated communication (i.e., news

articles), and what **similarities and differences** can

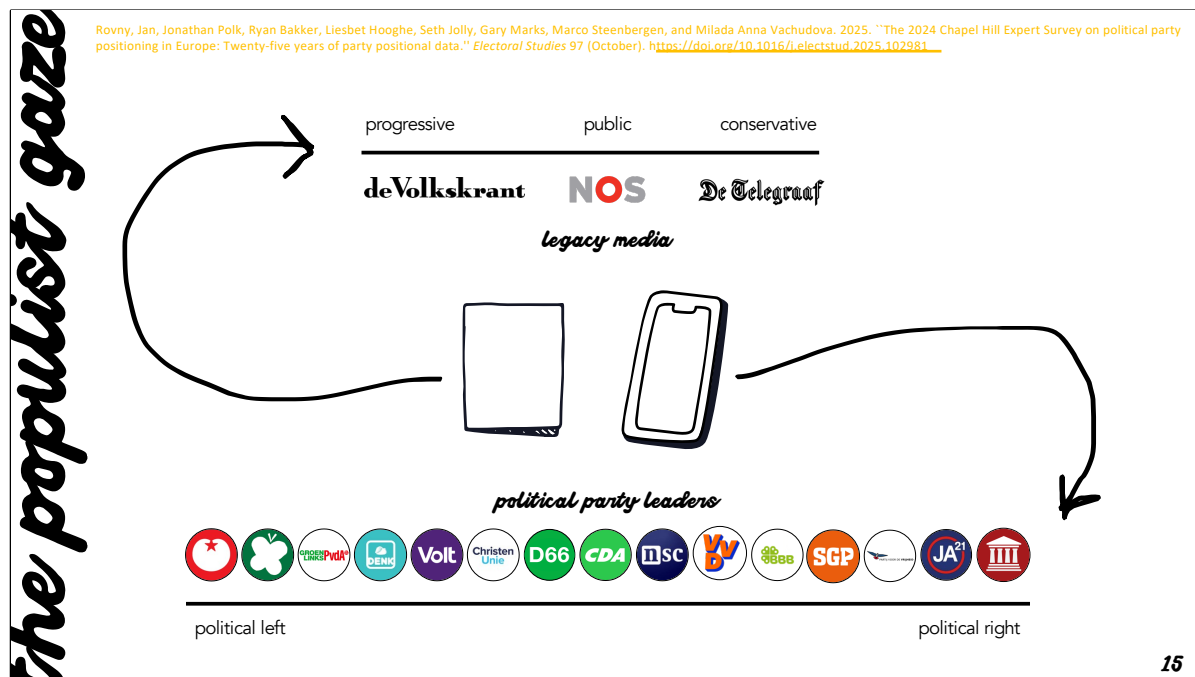
be identified across these two domains?

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This brings me to our research question:

To what extent is populist communication used on visual and textual messages within strategic communication and mediated communication, and what similarities and differences can be identified?

In other words, if you think back to the little opening exercise: is my mental image about Trump different when I inform myself through social media compared to legacy media, if it matters at all?



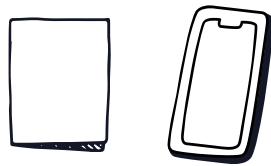
I study this, for now, in my home country: The Netherlands. The three outlets I study are semi left, semi right, and public.

For instagram, I include all political parties that have a seat in government.

The time period runs from September '23 to December '25 and includes two campaigns and one electoral cycle.

5,217 political articles

legacy media



political party leaders

9,492 images/thumbnails

This comes down to 5217 political articles, where a party or their leader was textually mentioned, visually depicted, or both, and 9492 instagram images.

legacy media



$N = 5,217$

political party leaders



$N = 9,492$

Once processed, that looks like this (yes, this is an actual example from my data)

So. We arrive at my favorite part of research: methodology.

How to operationalize multimodal populism in mediated versus strategic communication?

Ernst, N., Blassnig, S., Engesser, S., Büchel, F., & Esser, F. (2019). Populists Prefer Social Media Over Talk Shows: An Analysis of Populist Messages and Stylistic Elements Across Six Countries. *Social Media + Society*, 5(1), 2056305118823358. <https://doi.org/10.1177/2056305118823358>

dimensions of populist communication

0. Main topic (CAP)

1. References to "the people"

- 101. References to specific groups
- 102. Explicit references to "the" Dutch people

2. "Us versus them" framing

- 201. Intolerance to parties/politicians countries
- 202. Intolerance to societal groups

3. "Anti-elite" claims

- 301. Delegitimizing the political elite
- 302. Delegitimizing non-political elite

4. "Fatherland" references

- 401. References to the nation and/or national traditions
- 402. Symbols of Dutch culture

5. "One of us" leadership

- 501. (Visual) next to, with, or among citizens
- 502. Personalized political
- 503. Personalized non-political

6. "Crisis" as "threat" claims

- 601. Stating a crisis or crises
- 602. Speaking of threat(s)

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Inspired by a study by Nicole Ernst and her colleagues, who combine populist ideas with populist style elements in their operationalisation, we decided to look for different dimensions of populism that may or may not be adopted by any actor in our data. The dimension are as follows.

After a first round of coding, I added two subcategories of each type, and put this in a codebook with positive examples.

dimensions of populist communication



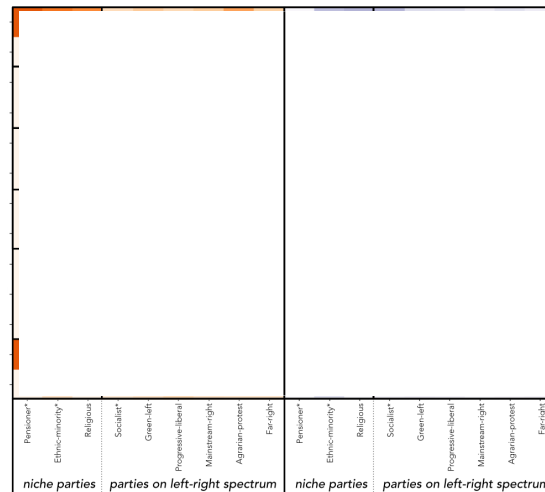
**PRELIMINARY
RESULTS**

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The preliminary results that I will present here are based on my own, manual annotations of 1500 instagram image-caption pairs and 1500 news image-headline pairs. This was preceded by two rounds of intercoder reliability checks based on size-150 subsamples for both sources of data.

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Normalized presence of populism (sub)dimensions



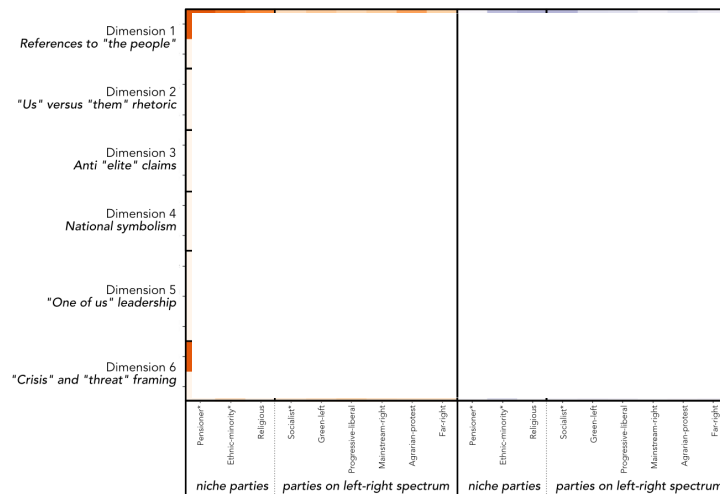
21

This is a very packed visualization of my results, so I will walk you through it. I group the 15 political parties of interest into 9 party families: a pensioner party, ethnic minority party, and religious party (I see these as niche party families), and the other party families that fit the left right political spectrum better: socialist, green-left parties, progressive-liberal parties, mainstream-right parties, agrarian-protest party, and far-right parties.

Note that party “families” with only one party grouped in them, are noted with an *. Very lonely parties...

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Normalized presence of populism (sub)dimensions

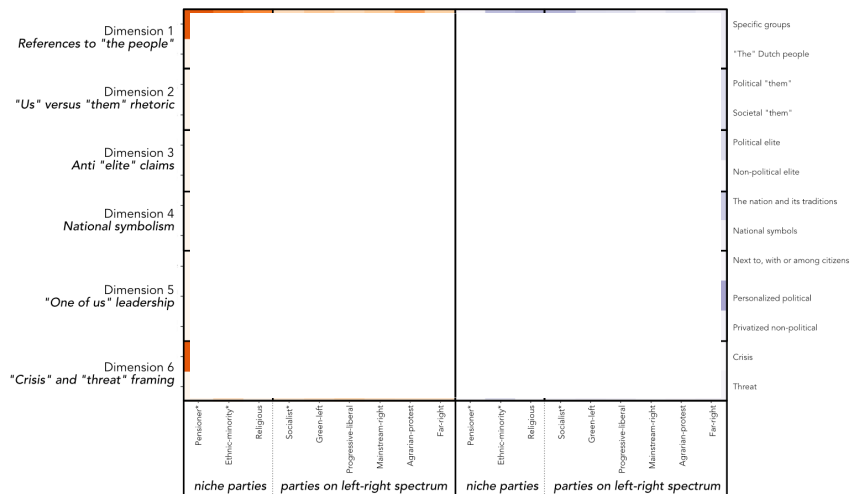


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The left axis represents the six populist dimensions

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Normalized presence of populism (sub)dimensions

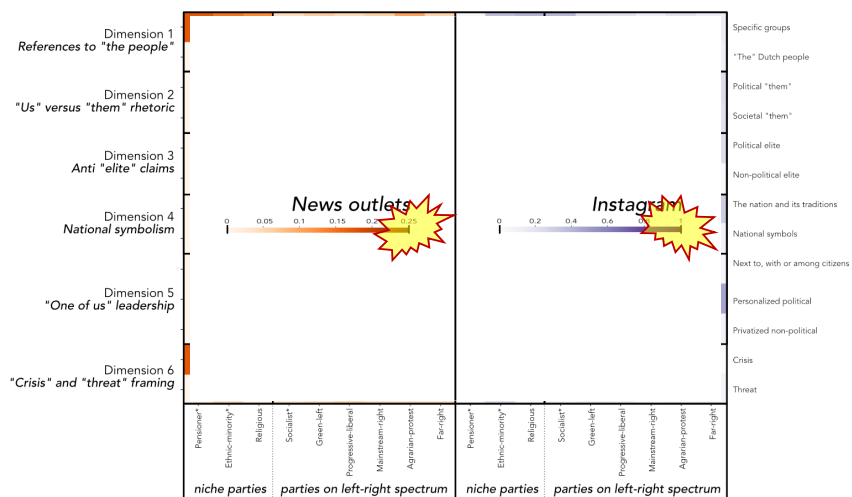


23

The right axis represents all subdimensions for each main dimension.

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Normalized presence of populism (sub)dimensions



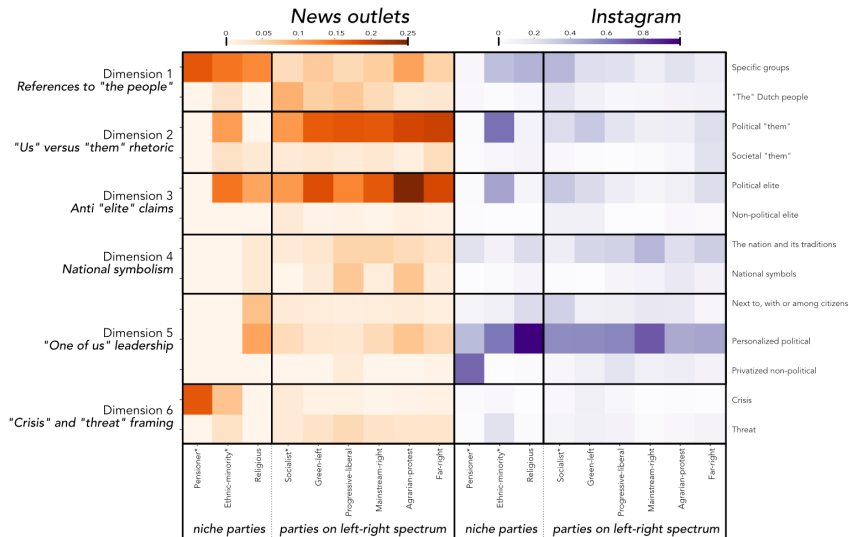
24

Importantly; the red-colored normalized axis count legend goes up to 0.25 for news outlets, where any color in the graph represents the normalized presence of a dimension in political news coverage for that dimension for that party family. If a party family appeared in the news 100 times, and 25 times with an us-versus-them frame, then the cell should be very red.

For instagram, this colored axis legend goes up to 1, which must be read as follows: for a party family, if a 100 out of a 100 instagram image-caption pairs for that party family includes the "one of us" dimension, the cell is bright purple.

dimensions of populist communication

Normalized presence of populism (sub)dimensions



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And that looks like this. I honestly am not sure yet how appropriate the chosen axes are and how fitting this heatmap is, but it does tell a lot of the different foci of the two media sources and where the inclusion of populist framing is most likely to appear.

In news coverage, the us-versus-them dimension and anti-elite claims stand out as most dominant populist dimensions compared to the other dimensions. And that is not that weird; democracy is, in essence, about conflict. Political news coverage predominantly focuses on the tensions between parties and between coalition, opposition, and sometimes also the European Union. Favoring some parties as the "us" and other parties as the "them" puts such political conflict in a populist frame.

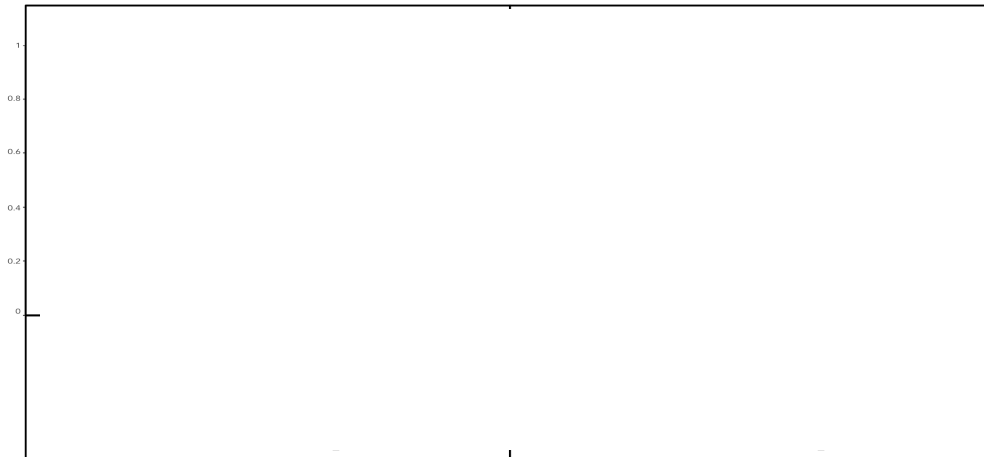
On the other hand, we find a totally different distribution on Instagram, where "one of us" leadership outweighs all other dimensions. Also this is easily explained by the communication dynamics of the platform, which stimulates an intimate, follower-to-viewer (or here: politician to public) relationship.

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Normalized modality distribution per subdimension

News outlets

Instagram

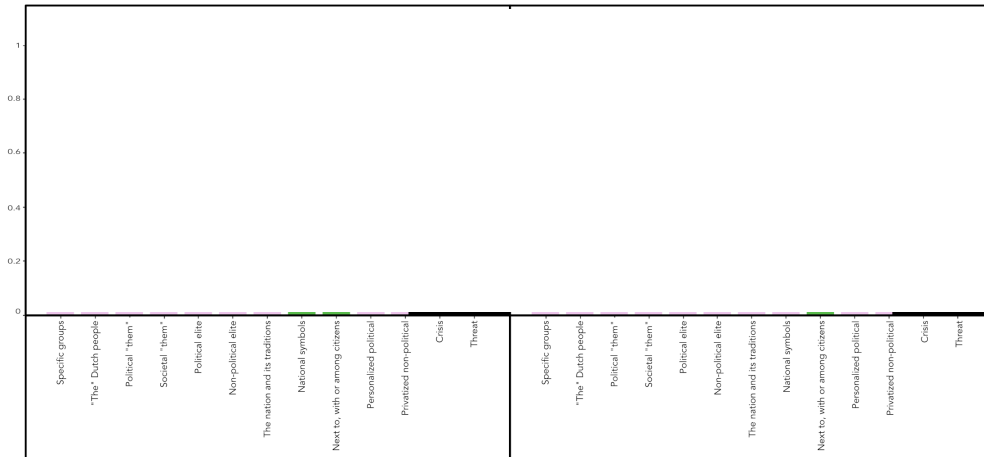


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But to what extent were these dimensions textual, visual, or multimodal?
We coded in a self-developed tool, in the annotator was first prompted with the text without the accompanying image.

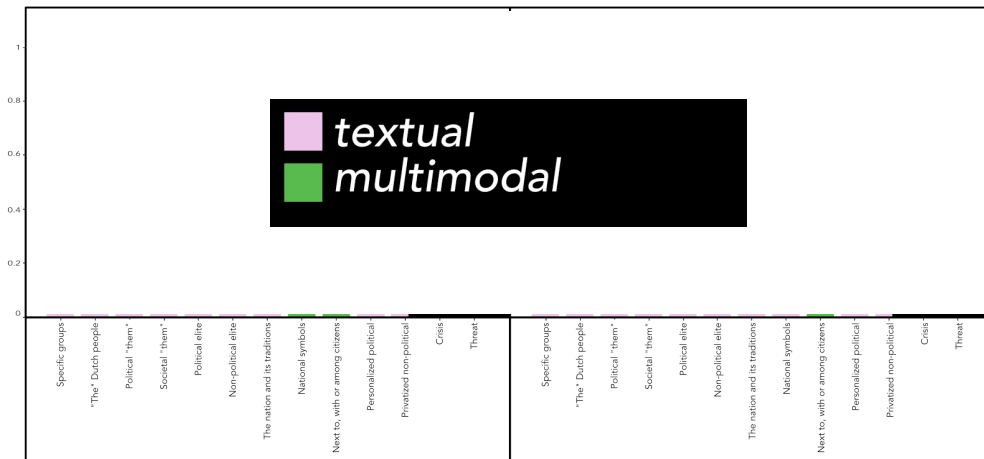
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Normalized modality distribution per subdimension
News outlets Instagram



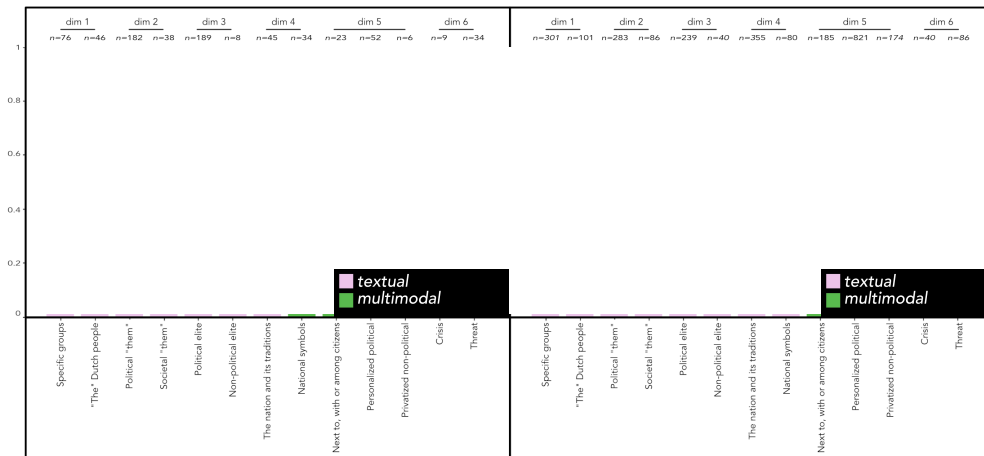
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Normalized modality distribution per subdimension
News outlets Instagram



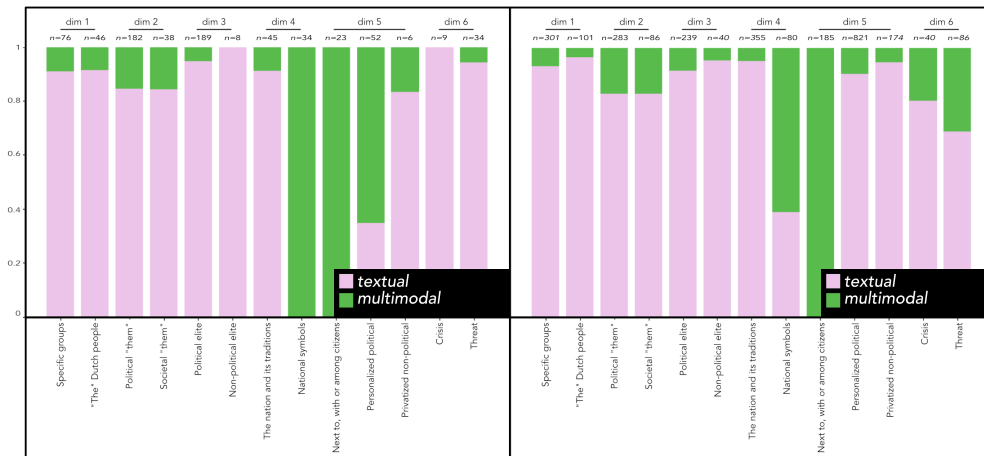
dimensions of populist communication

Normalized modality distribution per subdimension
News outlets Instagram

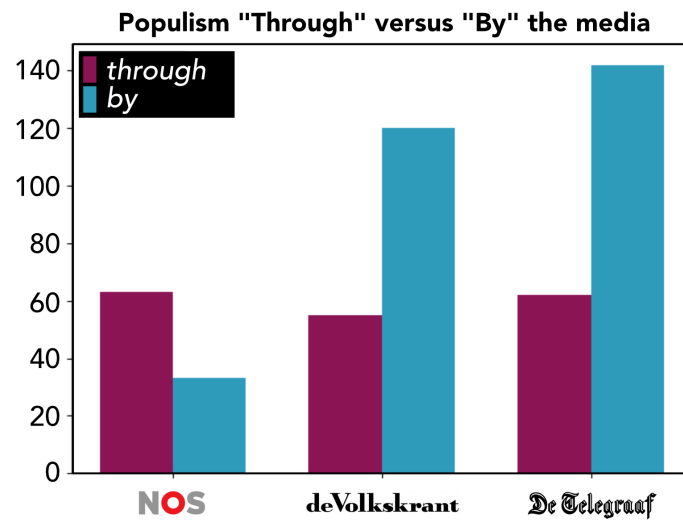


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Normalized modality distribution per subdimension
News outlets Instagram



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0. Main to

1. Referenc

101. Rei

102. Exp

2. "Us vers

201. Int

202. Int

3. "Anti-eli

301. De

302. De

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Visual	Textual	Codes	
	"Opinie: Zeker is er angst bij islamitische Nederlanders, maar óók vertrouwen in de rechtstaat. En: gevoel voor humor"	ID	VK_2023-11-23_VKbf1794b8
		Source	News
		Outlet	De Volkskrant
		Topic	Democracy
		Dimension	101
		Through or by	By
		Justification	The image suggests that there is a relation between Geert Wilders (PVV) and the
	"Wilders: extra geld voor defensie bespreekbaar, maar dan ook miljarden voor Nederlanders thuis"	ID	TG_2025-03-04_TG64387864
		Source	News
		Outlet	De Telegraaf
		Topic	15 (Defense), 19 (Government operations)
		Dimension	102
		Through or by	Through
		Justification	Politician Wilders (PVV) is depicted and quoted, making an appeal that expenditures for defense may not come at the cost of the Dutch people.

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the populist gaze

0. Main to

1. Referenc

101. Rel

102. Exp

2. "Us vers

201. Intv

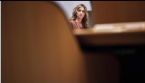
202. Intv

3. "Anti-eli

301. De

302. Dete

medi

Visual	Textual	Codes	
	"Timmermans en de zijnen laden met hun gekrijs verdenking op zich dat zij het liefst willen dat alles blijft zoals het was"	ID	TG_2024-06-16_TG64335078
		Source	News
		Outlet	De Telegraaf
		Topic	19 (Government operations)
		Dimension	201
		Through or by	By
	"Yesilgöz haalt uit naar XR en Greenpeace om ultimatum aan Rabobank: 'Dit raakt aan chantage'"	Justification	By framing "Timmermans en de zijnen" as "zij" (them), whilst Timmermans is a politician of GL-PvdA, the author contrasts them against an implicit in-group.
		ID	TG_2023-09-26_TG64240846
		Source	News
		Outlet	De Telegraaf
		Topic	2 (Civil rights)
		Dimension	202
		Through or by	Through
		Justification	The headline quotes Dilan Yesilgöz of the VVD party, who attacks two non-governmental activist groups, classifying their actions as bribe.

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cal actor next to

ssage

ails without political

0. Main topic

1. Reference

- 101. Refer
- 102. Expli

2. "Us versus

- 201. Intol
- 202. Intol

3. "Anti-elite

- 301. Dele
- 302. Dele
- medi

Visual	Textual	Codes	
	"Verzet tegen EU-klimaatheffing op gas en benzine groeit: vrees voor desastreuze financiële gevolgen van 'Timmermans-taks'" data-bbox="384 198 521 245"/>	ID	TG_2025-09-18_TG91260908
		Source	News
		Outlet	De Telegraaf
		Topic	18 (International affairs)
		Dimension	301
		Through/By	By
		Justification	The headline states a growing resistance against an EU measure that is presented as disastrous for the economy, and the result of a former member of the GL-PvdA party, who hence was part of the establishment.
	"Niks opgeschoten, maar aan de BBB lag het volgens de boeren niet: 'Door de Raad van State komen we nooit verder'" data-bbox="384 334 515 372"/>	ID	VK_2025-06-05_VKbd2d174d
		Source	News
		Outlet	De Volkskrant
		Topic	4. Agriculture
		Dimension	302
		Through/By	Through
		Justification	The image shows a traditional Dutch farm family that criticizes the highest state court institution "Raad van State".

